THE UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG
FACULTY OF BUSINESS AND ECONOMICS

MWM PMWM7016 Alternative Investments

GENERAL INFORMATION

Instructor: Adjunct Associate Prof. Joy Wang

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Consultation times:
By appointment, available in person before class at Cyberport (subject to scheduling) or via Zoom upon request.

Teaching Assistant: Donia Wang

Course Website: TBD

Reference Book:

- CAIA Level I: An Introduction to Core Topics in Alternative Investments (official CAIA Association textbook).

Note: Students who wish to pursue the CAIA designation may separately purchase Schweser Study Notes, but this is optional and not part of the required course materials.

- The latest industry white papers by leading GPs such as Blackstone, Bridgewater, Apollo, KKR, Brookfield, etc.

COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course provides a broad overview of alternative investments, including private equity, private credit, real estate, infrastructure, renewables, hedge funds, and digital assets. Students will engage with real-world cases from leading global firms such as Blackstone, KKR, Brookfield, Bridgewater, Blue Owl, and Partners Capital, gaining insights directly relevant for careers in alternative investments and private markets. The course emphasises applied frameworks, emerging trends like evergreen and semi-liquid structures, and culminates in a group investment pitch simulation that mirrors real-world investment committee practice.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

- Provide students with a broad understanding of alternative investments across private equity, private credit, real estate, infrastructure, renewable energy, hedge funds, and digital assets.
- Expose students to real-world decision-making through case studies on leading global GPs, including Blackstone, KKR, Brookfield, Bridgewater, Blue Owl, and Partners Capital.
- Equip students with product knowledge and applied frameworks for investment due diligence, strategy evaluation, and risk/return assessment, preparing them for careers in asset management, private markets, and private banks.
- Highlight the latest industry trends such as evergreen funds, semi-liquid structures (e.g., BREIT), and digital assets.
- Develop practical communication skills through the final 'Investment Pitch Simulation' presentation, mirroring real-world investment committee processes.

PROGRAMME LEARNING OUTCOMES

PLO1: Acquisition of the techniques and advanced knowledge in the interdisciplinary fields of wealth management including but not limited to financial services, technology and law: Students should acquire techniques and advanced knowledge in the interdisciplinary fields of wealth management including but not limited to financial services, technology and law.

PLO2: Application and integration of interdisciplinary knowledge and skills to identify and tackle practical problems, and design innovative products and systems with international standards and global vision: Students should be able to apply and integrate interdisciplinary knowledge and skills in the fields of wealth management to identify and tackle problems, and design innovative products and systems with international standards and global vision.

PLO3: Inculcating leadership, professional ethics and competence in the interdisciplinary fields of wealth management: Students should demonstrate the capacity to recognise, understand and develop appropriate options in ethical and social issues in the interdisciplinary fields of investment and wealth management. In their learning experiences, they will be working in teams that promote leadership training and development of leadership traits. In addition, they are to adhere to and respect university regulations on academic conduct.

PLO4: Mastering communication skills: Students should be able to articulate in public and be able to make convincing and coherent presentations, write effectively and use specific technical terminology in the interdisciplinary fields of wealth management in contemporary presentation tools context.

COURSE LEARNING OUTCOMES

Course Learning Outcomes	Aligned Programme Learning Outcomes
CLO1: Understand the characteristics, benefits, and risks of major alternative asset classes.	PLO1
CLO2: Analyze fund structures and evaluate vehicles such as co-investments, secondaries, evergreen funds, and semi-liquid models.	PLO1,2,4
CLO3: Apply due diligence frameworks to assess fund managers and strategies.	PLO2, 3, 4
CLO4: Engage in critical discussion of real-world cases from top alternative investment firms.	PLO3, 4
CLO5: Demonstrate the ability to deliver a professional investment pitch with clear analysis, persuasion, and handling of Q&A.	PLO3, 4

COURSE TEACHING AND LEARNING ACTIVITIES

Course Teaching and Learning Activities	Expected Hour	Study Load (% of study)
T&L1. Interactive lectures	30	23%
T&L2. In class discussions & presentations	20	15%
T&L3. Assignments & Case studies	40	31%
T&L4. Lecture preparation & Self-study	40	31%
Total	130 hours	100%

Assessment Methods	Brief Description (Optional)	Weight	Aligned Course Learning Outcomes
In class participation & discussion	Individual performance and participation in class.	35%	CLO1, 2, 3, 4
Case studies discussion & presentation	Group and individual bases. Discuss or present takeaways from the case studies of leading GPs, apply knowledge into real world scenarios	35%	CLO1, 2, 3, 4, 5
Final project (Group Investment Pitch Simulation)	Teams will prepare and present an alternative investment proposal. This project mirrors real-world investment committee dynamics.	30%	CLO1, 2, 3, 4, 5
	Total	100%	

STANDARDS FOR ASSESSMENT	
Course Grade Descriptors	
A+, A, A-	•Demonstrate a strong understanding of all relevant knowledge •Handling questions professionally •High participation in discussions •Present arguments that have an element of originality •Achieve a standard of excellent performance in the exams with very accurate computation and very good analytical and problem solving skills •Excellent performance in assignments
B+, B, B-	•Demonstrate a good understanding of all relevant knowledge •Handling questions in a logical way •Good participation in discussions •Present arguments that go beyond the lecture and textbook •Achieve a standard of good performance in the exams with accurate computation and good analytical and problem solving skills •Good performance in assignments
C+, C, C-	•Demonstrate a basic understanding of the concepts involved •Fairly address questions as set •Some participation in discussions •Present arguments in a well-structure manner •Meet a standard of acceptable performance in the exams with reasonably accurate computation and acceptable analytical and problem solving skills •Acceptable performance in assignments
D+, D	•Demonstrate a minimum understanding of the concepts involved •Barely address questions as set •Minimal or no participation in discussions •Present arguments in a marginally acceptable manner •Meet a standard of marginally acceptable performance in the exams with some errors in computation and barely adequate analytical and problem solving skills •Marginally acceptable performance in assignments
F	•Demonstrate a poor understanding of the concepts involved •Unable or unwilling to handle questions •Minimal or no participation in discussions •Present arguments poorly •Fail to meet a standard of passing the exams with major errors in computation and inadequate analytical and problem solving skills •Poorly performance in assignments
Assessment Rubrics for Participation	
A+, A, A-	•High participation in discussions •Always attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a strong understanding of all relevant knowledge •Handling questions professionally •Present arguments that have an element of originality •Respect others and follow the class rules (no chatting and do not use cell phone)
B+, B, B-	•Good participation in discussions •Often attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a good understanding of all relevant knowledge •Handling questions in a logical way •Present arguments that go beyond the lecture and textbook •Respect others and follow the class rules (no chatting and do not use cell phone)

C+, C, C-	•Some participation in discussions •Sometimes attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a basic understanding of the concepts involved •Fairly address questions as set •Present arguments in a well-structure manner •Respect others and follow the class rules (no chatting and do not use cell phone)
D+, D	•Minimal or no participation in discussions •Rarely attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a minimum understanding of the concepts involved •Barely address questions as set •Present arguments in a marginally acceptable manner •Respect others and follow the class rules (no chatting and do not use cell phone)
F	•Minimal or no participation in discussions •Almost never attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a poor understanding of the concepts involved •Unable or unwilling to handle questions •Present arguments poorly •Behave poorly in class (often chatting with others, using cell phones, or being late)
A+, A, A-	
B+, B, B-	•Demonstrate a good understanding of all relevant knowledge •Present arguments that go beyond the lecture and textbook •Achieve a standard of good performance in the assessments with accurate computation and good analytical and problem solving skills
C+, C, C-	•Demonstrate a basic understanding of the concepts involved •Present arguments in a well-structure manner •Meet a standard of acceptable performance in the assessments with reasonably accurate computation and acceptable analytical and problem solving skills
D+, D	•Demonstrate a minimum understanding of the concepts involved •Present arguments in a marginally acceptable manner •Meet a standard of marginally acceptable performance in the assessments with some errors in computation and barely adequate analytical and problem solving skills
F	•Demonstrate a poor understanding of the concepts involved •Present arguments poorly •Fail to meet a standard of passing the assessments with major errors in computation and inadequate analytical and problem solving skills
A+, A, A-	•Demonstrate a strong understanding of all relevant knowledge •Present arguments that have an element of originality •Achieve a standard of excellent performance in the assessments with very accurate computation and very good analytical and problem solving skills

COURSE CONTENT AND TENTATIVE TEACHING SCHEDULE

Week 1 – Oct 13: Introduction to Alternative Investments

- Overview of alternative asset classes, industry trends (US, EMEA, Asia).
- Why investors allocate to alternatives; role in portfolios.
- Activity: Class poll/discussion on 'Why alternatives, why now?'.

Week 2 – Oct 16: Fund Structures & Vehicles

- GP/LP, co-investments, secondaries, liquid vs drawdown, evergreen.
- Case: Partners Capital: Launching Private Investing Evergreen Funds for Retail Investors

Week 3 – Oct 25 (Sat): Private Equity

- Life cycle, exits, GP/LP dynamics. PE across different models.
- Case: Blackstone Strategic Partners
- Case: KKR

Week 4 – Oct 23: Private Credit I: Direct Lending & Mezzanine

- Direct lending, mezzanine structures.
- Case: Blue Owl Financing of Ping Identity

Week 5 – Oct 27: Private Credit II: Distressed & Insurance-Anchored Credit

- Distressed investing, hybrid models, insurance capital.
- Continuation: Blue Owl Financing of Ping Identity (same case, deeper dive into credit/insurance).

Week 6 – Oct 30: Real Estate & REITs

- Private CRE vs REITs, valuation frameworks.
- Case: Blackstone at 35: Performance, Innovation, and the Next Generation

Week 7 – Nov 3: Infrastructure & Renewables

- Infra debt/equity, renewable energy, ESG, sustainability integration.
- Case: Brookfield Renewable Partners – Is Entropy a Sustainable Investment?

Week 8 – Nov 6: Hedge Funds

- Macro, quant, long/short, relative value.
- Case 1: Bridgewater: Developing Its Business in China
- Case 2: Who Wants to Be a Millionaire? Bill Ackman’s Big Short of Herbalife

Week 9 – Nov 10: Digital Assets & Emerging Trends

- Blockchain, tokenization, DeFi, institutional adoption, risks.
- Case: Does Bitcoin Belong on Your Balance Sheet?

Week 10 – Nov 13: Final Group Presentations – Investment Pitch Simulation

- Groups of 5–6 students (12–15 groups).
- Task: Pitch an alternative investment strategy or vehicle (10 min presentation + 2 min Q&A).
- Evaluation: Content (40%), Application (30%), Delivery (20%), Q&A (10%).
- Strict timing managed by TA.

REQUIRED/RECOMMENDED READINGS & ONLINE MATERIALS (e.g. journals, textbooks, website addresses etc.)

To be announced on Moodle.

MEANS/PROCESSES FOR STUDENT FEEDBACK ON COURSE

- Online response via Moodle site
- Others: ___SFTL_____ (please specify)

COURSE POLICY (e.g. plagiarism, academic honesty, attendance, etc.)

An orderly learning environment is extremely important for this course. Disruptive behaviors are absolutely unacceptable. Academic dishonesty includes cheating, plagiarism, unauthorized collaboration, falsifying academic records, and any act designed to avoid participating honestly in the learning process. Any such dishonesty will result in an F grade.

ADDITIONAL COURSE INFORMATION (e.g. e-learning platforms & materials, penalty for late assignments, etc.)

Assignments will be submitted in class before the lectures. No late assignments will be accepted.
Lecture notes and self-learning materials will be uploaded to Moodle.
Good questions and discussions on Moodle will be awarded participation grades.